Perhaps he was playing to a gallery at home used to such tropes of ‘incredible India’. Or, as Schwanbeck suggests, perhaps he placed excessive trust in his native informants, likely royal Brahmins or other literate courtiers, who solemnly related tall tales about the rakshasas, pishachas and Mlecchas in the forests and lands beyond.[15] To the extent the latter is true, his account may also be a revealing window into Brahminical social attitudes of the day.

Three centuries later, Strabo and Pliny criticized him for ‘deviating into fables’ too gullibly, even as they found other parts of his account useful. Fortunately, the outlandish sections are few in number, and for the places he did visit, including Pataliputra where he was an ambassador, his account is more sober and seems based on personal observation and experience. His errors there tend to be the kind that could’ve been occupational hazards for any traveller of his day. What, then, did Megasthenes observe in Mauryan India?

The Mauryan World in 300 BCE

Megasthenes calls Pataliputra (‘Palibothra’ in his account) the greatest city in India. It lies at the confluence of rivers Ganga and Son. Shaped like a parallelogram, 15 km x 3 km, the city is enclosed by a wooden wall with slits for shooting arrows. It has 570 watchtowers and sixty-four gates (averaging one gate every 500 m). Around the wall is a defensive moat, 180 m wide and 15 m deep, which also carries the city’s sewage. If Megasthenes is right, Pataliputra’s dimensions would make it the largest city of the ancient world—‘twice as large as Rome under Emperor Marcus Aurelius’.[16]

Much of the city, including the king’s palace, is made of wood. This is because, explains Megasthenes, Indian cities located on floodplains are ‘built of wood instead of brick’ and ‘cities which stand on commanding situations and lofty eminences are built of brick and mud’. (Later Mauryan kings did build with stone, but this may partly explain the relative lack of archaeological remains of Pataliputra. Besides fragments of the wooden wall at many sites, the most notable find has been ‘a Mauryan pillared hall of [eighty] polished sandstone monoliths comparable to the pillared palace